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Original Page: 74**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1964**Coverage Date:** Ca. 1958-1964**Place Coverage:** G/Wi San, Botswana**Section Title(S):** (3) Esteem. • (4) Social Control.

Activities in which skill commands prestige are, of course, the primary economic activities of hunting and food-gathering and their subsidiaries, the accurate prediction of movements of game and the availability of food plants in their season in different parts of the band's territory. A maker of good arrows enjoys not only the esteem of his fellows, but is frequently asked for their loan, in return for which he gets a share of the meat of the animals killed. Outstanding skin-workers and toolmakers benefit less directly from their skill, but are in demand as advisers and helpers to those less gifted, and it is their willingness to help, more than their skill, which gives them standing in the band. Among the social activities virtuosity in dancing and storytelling win prestige.

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From the point of view of the individual, the activity in which he excels is more important than the prestige it gains him. He will not, therefore, perfect his skill only for the sake of the reward of the admiration and standing it will bring him, although this motive does act as some encouragement.

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(4) *Social Control.*

The problem in an egalitarian society with every man equal in status to every other, is, who is to exercise control over the individual? In our own society one might rather ruefully invert the question and ask who does not control him? Whereas our own society is not necessarily the best governed, it is certainly among the most governed, and it is accordingly difficult for us to visualize a society in which there are no formal organs and institutions of government whatsoever. With no Police, Judges or Courts, how is crime punished or

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prevented and how are disputes between persons settled? In the absence of anything resembling chieftainship, who gives direction to the aspirations of the forty or sixty souls composing the band? In this amorphous whole, who is to be spokesman for the band in its dealings with other bands? The brief answer to all three questions is, public opinion. The explanation of its operation is, however, somewhat lengthier. In the first place, the G/wi do not ramify the acts of an individual, as we do, into separate categories, e.g. into crimes, delicts, breaches of etiquette and socio-legal acts such as marriages. These are all actions which affect the welfare of the band as a whole and are dealt with in the same way as are decisions to move to another part of the band's territory to seek a fresh supply of game or food plants.

The upbringing of the child and the atmosphere of the band make the G/wi a conforming people and transgressions of their unformulated code of behaviour are rare. Theft is pointless, as one is permitted free use of the possessions of one's joking partners and in such a small, tightly-knit community as the band, one has very little hope of not being detected. Violence is generally too dreadful even to contemplate, and only takes the form of wife or husband beating. Even this does not amount to more than an exchange of bruising blows, or a wife may pick up an ash-scraper and crack it over her husband's head, but no permanent or continued fighting. Persistent laziness and unprovoked outbursts of temper are also considered offences. Other transgressions are unseemly behaviour towards avoidance kin, bad manners generally and the breaking of borrowed property without offering redress. All these  75 earn the censure of the band. This is an effective punishment and deterrent as it constitutes a form of ex-communication from the band. The offender is not actually expelled, but is made to feel that, as his conduct is beyond the pale, he is not nice to be near. The need for companionship is very strong indeed and when deprived of it by having earned censure, the offender feels his loneliness keenly. He then apologizes or shows by his conduct that he has sincerely repented of his sins and is forgiven. The offence is, however, not forgotten and its memory may be invoked to remind the offender, or anybody else likely to repeat the offence, of the consequences of such behaviour.

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